AFRICAN SUN

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World News

Mandela and de Klerk Receive Nobel Prize

The co-recipients of the 1993 Nobel Peace Prize were African National Congress President Nelson Mandela and F.W. de Klerk. The men were selected by the Norwegian Nobel Committee for their efforts to putting an end Apartheid in South Africa. The men have worked together in an attempt to establish a new "one man-one vote" political order in the country. Only two other South Africans, prior to Mandela and de Klerk, have been honored with the prestigious award: Albert Luthuli in 1960 and Bishop Desmond Tutu in 1984.

Faculty Corner

Dean's World

In Pursuit of Academic Excellence and Relevant Other Matters along the way.

by Lydia L. English, Ph.D.

My Dear Sisters and Brothers,

In this letter to you I want to discuss some of the core essential values necessary, though not wholly sufficient, in the pursuit of academic excellence, Broadly defined these values are responsibility, respect, and reason. I am writing to you because I want to convey a sense of urgency about our academic mission, a message of hope for positive transformations of our interpersonal relationships and our institutional relationships.

We are very accustomed to railing against racism. Racism is a fact of American society. Its effects are pernicious, yet we black people are far more than the containment of racist ideologies. Racism is something we Blacks in America and other parts of the world must continuously struggle to overcome. We must more conscientiously balance our energy in fighting racism from the outside so that the energy we expend on vigilance does not deplete the energy we need for self-introspection and the correction of debilitating disruptive patterns. We must be about mending the torn fabric of our communities and healing the deep wounds of self-abrogation..

We are fighting so many personal battles within our own circles and communities that we often fail to see the forest for the trees. I have heard West Indian or African students try to disclaim any relationship to African American students because they think and feel that being anything other than Black in America is better. I have heard brown skin Latinos and bi-racial students embrace parts of their heritage and abhor their African descent. Yet the reality in the United States is that all of us of color are viewed by white ideology as Black (i.e., inferior, other, scapegoat) no matter where we come from. The conflicts that arise among us Black folk, —woman and woman, woman against man, man against woman, man against man— are draining our psychic and spiritual energy. We are left spent for our daunting task and serious

mission of educational achievement, that is essential to pass hope along to our next generation.

We don't have the luxury of discriminating against each other on the basis of looks, color, national origin, sex, sexual orientation, money, lifestyle, interests, religion or any of the myriad other causes that people find to make a difference. Black people are diverse and complex. We are not all the same and we should not expect some kind of uniformity. We share the difference of unique personalities, and we share the commonalty of a history of struggle to be where we are today. We are standing on the backs of hundreds of thousands of black souls, whose blood, sweat, tears, and lives have created a space for us. We cannot afford to divide ourselves on these superficial categories. The chief strategy of our enemies and detractors has always been "Divide and Conquer." If we are not about being our own advocates and supporters, who will be for us?

You are the hope for the future, the link between the past and the present. You are the *"Creme de la Creme"*. This is an awesome responsibility, but one we cannot afford to abdicate.

I am writing you this small correspondence as a small effort to open up and to facilitate continuous dialogue on the subject of our relationships to each other, our communities, and our academic commitment. I hope that you will be encouraged to begin to explore creative visions beyond the scope of tradition and deficit patterns. We need to engage our minds more through casual discussion, through study groups and through individual study— not to just study our subjects, but to think about them critically. All of the great prophets, teachers and many voices of the common people have always exhorted us to **Know Our History.**

Sometimes we feel shame, guilt, and embarrassment when we study the history of Blacks in America. There is a lot to be angry about in Black History. When we study and think about the degradations, humiliations, pain, suffering, and death that millions of our forebears endured, we have a right to be angry. But anger is like nitroglycerin; it can be a creative force and save your life ,or it can be an explosive force and kill you. Many of us carry around a very heavy weight of anger. This anger manifest itself in back-stabbing, envy, gossip, disrespect, fear, guardedness, phoniness, and plenty of other behaviors and attitudes that keeps us apart. This is called internalized racism. Derrick Bell, former Harvard professor of law and author of Faces at the Bottom of the Well, sheds some light our patterns to hold on to some of the debilitating postures, positions and behaviors that form our everyday presentations of self. To paraphrase Bell, part of the answer is a latent mostly unconscious tendency toward self-deprecation that is unavoidably instilled in people subordinated by outside forces. Too many people have turn this righteous anger inwardly into themselves and onto the people around them. We have tended to dwell and obsess on our pain rather to move on in the spirit of cooperation, communication, and respect to our healing.

"The Price of the Ticket", a video about the life and death of James Baldwin, provides an enriched inspiration to blossom in the reflected light of Black Pride. In this documentary, Baldwin reaches out from a higher level to remind us that historical, cultural and spiritual amnesia will kill us. Baldwin's passion cries out a to a world

engulfed in fear. He says, the secret to our existence is love, and that love is the hardest essence to hold on to. Love, according to Baldwin, is a quality of state in which every human being has the right to dignity and respect. Love is a structure of affect and response in which we compelled automatically to be nice to each other. It is a state wherein being in someone's presence commands your empathy and compassion. Baldwin quite aptly laid it on the line when he said, "Love can not happen until you trust you and I trust me. That means facing the truth and being free."

Our Black History is a history of human lives, the victories, the successes, the defeats, the failures, the joys and the sorrows, the laughter and the tears. Our Black History is a tale a thousand thousand times told of ingenuity, strength, courage, intelligence, compassion and love. In this short passage from Faces at the Bottom of the Well, Derrick Bell concludes a story he is telling about the lost continent of *Afrolantica* after the island resurfaced from the depths of the sea and subsequently reemerged into the sea:

> the spirit of cooperation that has engaged a few hundred thousand blacks spread to others, as they recalled the tenacity for humane life which had enabled generations of blacks to survive all efforts to dehumanize or obliterate them. Infectious, their renewed tenacity reinforced their sense of possessing themselves. Blacks held fast, like a talisman, the quiet convic tion that Afrolantica had not been mere mirage—that somewhere in the word America, somewhere irrevocable and profound, there is as well the word Afrolantica. [p.49]

Black history is also a valiant history of black women and men joining in a series of miracles of cooperative effort to repel the odious cancer of self-denial. We have had and have our great teachers, our great speakers, our great scholars, our great politicians, and our great hard workers in all fields. We have our role-models and we cannot forget them or let them down. For as Maya Angelou has so poignantly told us, "you are paid for", and with that investment comes the responsibility and the commitment to be all there is for us to be.

There are many black martyrs to the cause of intellectual freedoms. Some of our ancestors were killed for learning to read and to write. Many were killed for speaking out. But the value of having voice, giving voice, and owning your own thoughts far outweigh human measure. Our forebears, have paid the ultimate price, with their lives, for our right to the pursuit of knowledge, intellectual security, happiness and to compassion.

I want to urge you to stay actively involved in your education. You have the honor and the privilege to attain one of the finest educations in the world. You have the opportunity to meet and share all forms of diversity with people from all over the world. Take full advantage of this once in a lifetime opportunity of your college years to build a foundation of interest in life that will serve you for the rest of your life. You have the opportunity to talk to, confer with, get advice from and give advice to your faculty and your deans. We are here to help you to make the best of your education. Come to meet us, and use us to help you envision the best for yourself. The deans and the faculty are here in the service of higher education and scholarship. We are members of the Brown community who are committed the mission of facilitating the intellectual and personal growth of students.

Black people have traditionally viewed law and medicine as our primary symbols of status and success, and we need our lawyers and our doctors. But our knowledge and our insight is crucial in many other fields. We must break out of this constricting model of success and strive for representation in all areas of human endeavor. Consider becoming a role-model in higher education. Imagine, Learn, Teach, Share, Communicate!

•There are special educational opportunities availible for students of color in terms of fellowships, summer programs, scholarships, graduate school opportunities, degree programs, etc. Those interested may contact Dean Lydia English at Box 1972.

Free Your Mind...

Response to Poor Support for The Black Experience at Brown

As the coordinators of **The Black Experience at Brown** weekend, we feel compelled to remark upon the apathy of many in the Black community towards this year's program. This year over 1400 invitations were sent to high school seniors of which only 200 could be selected. The consequence of this selection process by a committee composed of the Senior Associate Director of Admission, the coordinators, and two members of the minority review committee was that the prospectives who visited Brown represented the top students in the country. When it came time to physically providing accommodations for these students, however, we never anticipated the lack of willingness and enthusiasm on the part of Brown students to house and interact with the prospectives.

It is disheartening and pathetic that we were reduced to begging for cooperation for a program that has been established for the benefit of the Black community. Not only did we mail out volunteer forms to every single student registered as being of African descent (about four hundred), but when we only received thirty responses, we doubled our efforts. We made multiple call-outs, postered the campus, and engaged in what could be considered personal campaigning. For the first time, the Admissions Office had to table-slip the dining halls in yet another effort to capture your attention. It should embarrass every member of the Black community to know that members of the Asian-American and Latino communities were more than willing to house and support a recruitment program not even geared for members of their communities. Despite their willingness and the temptation to follow a simpler path, we remained committed to the purpose of the program and managed to find Black students who extended themselves to house five or six people (it was the first time that we accepted offers from students who live off campus).

Despite our disappointment with the response of the general Black community, we do not wish to appear ungrateful for the participation of those students who were supportive of the program and helped make it as successful as it proved to be. However, we cannot allow the clear apathy of many to remain unchecked. Let us not forget that we are here due to the accomplishments of those who came before us. They too struggled to pave a path while enduring academic and social pressures. If we do not continue their efforts, we will surely be the last. As a people striving to build a community for the future, we must guide our actions towards this common goal.

Karen Alexander ''96
Michele Pierre-Louis ''95
Andrea Anderson ''96
Chris Modesto ''95

To all the Black Men who feel Neglected, Disrespected, labeled as a Dogg, Overlooked and Underrepresented

this is written to you, for you and about you.

Let's take a trip down memory lane. Back in the day, whe we were still being unloaded off of the ships, who was tight packed in there with you, through the suffering, the pain, breathing the American stench into our nostrils? Who emerged with the mixed black fammily on Her back? How soon we forget!!

We, as tired, concerned angry black women, are tired of the same old broken record. It is time for a new tune. The STRUGGLE? The STRUGGLE! The STRUGGLE. Who's struggle? Your struggle? My struggle? No...OUR struggle. Tell me, when did we leave you behind and reach the mountain top? My feet, my arms, my back, and my soul are still aching. I still haven't found a place to rest. Look, I'm still by your side. Can't you see me through the tears and sweat in your own eyes? Have you really ever seen me? Do you know me? Do you Understand me? I think not!

Since the journey has brought us to Brown, let's break it down:

1. You call us Queen? Your Sista? Your Girl? The " Woman?" The"Shit?"
   Don't play yourself. You don't even respect us.

2. You want to use our minds and bodies, but since you don't want the total package you go to other schools, other races, anywhere and every where, but "home."
3. You say we are not "down" like our Johnson and Wales sista, but just because we refuse to play your game (a game that we are tired of) doesn't mean that our noses are stuck in the air and we think we are all "that."
4. You are offended when we call you Dogg, then who are you calling Bitch?
5. Black man you are so spoiled. Your egos have been catered to. Your sexual appetite has been overly satisfied. You have been well fed. The kitchen is CLOSED!

"YOU BETTER CHECK YOURSELF BEFORE YOU WRECK YOURSELF!"

As we have recognized your plight, it is time for you to recognize ours, and your role in it. Don't silence our voice as you have in the past.

Signed,
Sistas who speak the truth!

...from the Editors

We, the editors and staff of the African Sun are dismayed by the apparent apathy of the Black community here at Brown University. The absence of sensational issues such as Harambee House, guns at Brown, and the Haitian immigration controversy have seemingly resulted in the absence of sustained dialogue (hence, absence of submissions to the African Sun!!) on issues of importance our community. If the only time that we share our ideas is when something detrimental threatens the community, then where are weheading as an intellectual force to be reckoned with? It was our understanding when accepting leadership of the Sun that it would be used as a forum through which the community would express your much valued knowledge. Let's reflect: are you satisfied with your status as Blacks in a still very white society? Speak to us !

-Signed
Sisters with no Submissions

Class of '96, Listen Up!... Class of '97, Get Ready!

Brothers and Sisters in the Class of '96, I implore you to check out the Mellon Minority Fellowship Program. The Mellon Fellowship is open to Black, Latino, and Native American sophomores who plan to pursue doctoral studies in the humanities and social sciences. Mellon fellows receive stipends to conduct research projects for the remainder of their undergraduate careers, in addition to attending academic conferences and seminars, and networking with others in academia. Upon receiving their bachelors degrees, Mellon fellows are awarded **$10, 000!!** to relieve their undergraduate loans, if they have been accepted in Ph.D. programs. The goal of the Mellon program is to increase the number of "folks" who receive doctorate degrees.

My personal experience as a Mellon fellow speaks to the perks of this program. This past summer I worked with David Savran in the English department on his EL 147 course, finding materials by LGB people of color to include in the syllabus. Currently I'm Michael Dyson's research assistant, and as his assistant, I got the chance to give a guest lecture in his Afro-Am 9 class. This April, I'm going to attend a national conference for undergraduate researchers, at which I plan to present my Afro-Am 9 lecture. I tell you these things not to pump my ego—*I can do that on my own time, thank you very much!* (just kidding)—but rather to let you know of just some of the advantages that the Mellon Fellowship offers.

Sophomores, if you are interested, contact Dean Lydia English (x2412, Box 1972, 117 Rhode Island Hall) for more information. The deadline for applications is March 1st, so you need to jump on this a.s.a.p. **Freshmen**, it's imperative to start thinking about your future NOW! Too many of us don't pay enough attention to academics early on, making us ineligible for fellowships and grants when we become upperclassmen. If you have even the slightest interest in the Mellon, please, please, please-baby, please-baby, please... contact Dean English, or call me (x6326) to rap about it.

- Ed Brockenbrough '95

Deep Thoughts (dedicated to Calvin Broadus)

"It made me want to drive coldly to the heart of every question and lay it open to the core of suffering I knew I would find there. It made me love burrowing into psychology, into realistic and naturalistic fiction and art, into those whirlpools of politics that had the power to claim thw whole of men's souls. It directed my loyalties to the side of men in rebellion; it made me love talk that could insight answers to questions that could help nobody, that could only keep alive in me that enthralled sense of wonder and awe in the face of the drama of human drama of human feeling which is hidden by the external drama of life."

-Richard Wright, Black Boy

It Is "The White Man's Fault"

by E.I. mFelton
andJ.M. Herrera

Some don't give a damn/'Cause they the other man
Worse than a bomb/Posin' as Uncle Tom's
Disgracin' the race/Blowin' up the whole crew
Wit' some of them lookin' just like you
-Public Enemy, *Nighttrain*, 1991

Some black people have short memories. In an unprincipled, disorganized attempt to explain our current urban crisis, the black middle class has fallen for one of the oldest tricks in the oppressors' playbook--getting the victims to blame themselves. To assert publicly, without qualification, that the problems of African-Americans today "are not the white man's fault" is a dangerous concession, for any brotha or sista, to make. Today, the "white man" is still an accurate metaphor for the dual legacy of European expansionism since Columbus: white supremacy and capitalist exploitation.

Playwright and cultural critic, Amiri Baraka, after becoming a Communist (thus elevating the argument of class struggle above the confines of black nationalism), retained the usage of "whitey" as a potent metaphor. He explained that "[he] understood that to characterize [his] ideology as hate whitey is accurate since the only whitey is system and ideology, that whitey is a class..." In this context, "whitey," is a definite set of economic relations (the market system) and the non-economic forces (racism, sexism, etc.) that keeps it functioning. While this "whitey" continues to be dominated by the white males of European descent, history has shown us that such a distinction is not limited to whites. In fact, brothas and sistas at Brown are among the most eagerly recruited blacks to maintain "whitey's" system. Our inability, and often unwillingness, to challenge this system characterizes a real political crisis. This essay will explore the contours of this emergency.

The majority of middle class blacks are politically conservative. The differences between Democrats and Republicans become negligible because they share the distiction of having uncritically embraced most of the values and ideological assumptions associated with Americasn political and cut-throat competition, ethnocentricism, and the conviction that "equality of opportunity" shouldn't guarantee "equality of result." This necessitates a critique of black liberalism, an ideological "box," that has deracialized the black middle-class and its aspirants. If we can demystify this liberal ethic, we can begin to explain why issues of political importance in the Brown black community are so narrowly defined.

In his bestseller *Race Matters* Cornel West exposes the faculty reasoning that informs the politics of both traditional black leaders--card carryin' NAACP and Urban League members--and their conservative Clarence Thomas, Thomas Sowell, Shelby Steele, and Stephen Carter-Supportin' counterparts. While black liberals view racism as the "sole cause of the predicament of the black working poor and the very poor," conservatives "link the moral breakdown of poor black communities to the expansion of the welfare state." With few exceptions, brothas and sistas at Brown can be divided neatly into one of these two camps. However, behind this veneer of divisions exists a

deeper, unspoken solidarity among brothas and sistas—an allegiance to the maintenance and reproduction of class privilege.

In his most celebrated volume, *The Wretched of the Earth,* Frantz Fanon admonishes black elites to "repudiate its own nature in so far as it is bourgeois, that is to say in so far as it is the tool of capitalism, and to make class descendants of these elites, brothas and sistas at Brown should be attentive to Fanon's advice. To the extent that Brown exists to ensure that access to political and economic power rests in the hands of the very few, we can all be implicated by association in this betrayal of democracy. Consequently, we must not let our political work be limited to eliminating overt instances of racism, sexism, and homophobia. Pursued in isolation, these struggles only serve to validate the "boojie" lifestyles and career decisions of many brothas and sistas. That is, they fail to see the contradiction between their personal crusades against discrimination based upon color, gender or sexual orientation and their own desires to become the pawns of labor exploitation and capital accumulation under "whitey's system.

We must investigate the relationship between these different oppressions and the uneven distribution of material resources under capitalism. Undoubtedly, if black men weren't regarded as "violent" and "untrustworthy," if sistas were never reduced to the disrespectful category of "bitch" and even if the black church openly embraced queer lifestyles, we would still be in the midst of a profound social and economic crisis.

For brothas and sistas truly interested in many of the issues we've raised, we encourage you to read *How Capitalism Underdeveloped Black America* by Manning Marable.

A Cornerstone in the Foundation of Black Literature

by Robb Dimmick

Black-owned bookstores are a rare commodity. Those specializing in out-of-print African American books further reduce the number. In New England there is only one and Providence, RI is fortunate to find its presence. Located in the leafy shadow of Brown University, along the quieter, tree-lined splendor of Thayer Street, south of Waterman Street, Cornerstone Books holds forth in a small but literary space at 127, nestled between Corner Variety and Ruby's Restaurant. Founded ten years ago as a mail-order business, Ray Rickman quickly elaborated it into a small shop on Brook Street where it shortly became the off-campus hotspot for budding Brown literati, hosting poetry and prose readings to standing room gatherings. These smaller-scale events enabled the larger undertaking of a lecture series, that over ten years has invited James Balwin, Maya Angelou, Terry McMillan (one of her first public appearances), Arnold Rampersad, Henry Louis Gates and more recently, Caribbean author Caryl Phillips and National Book Award nominee, David Levering Lewis, to town.

Cornerstone's specialty has always been in assisting its clientele, whether on the low-budget end or the upper scale with their literary needs, be they academic or investment oriented. To that end they inventory a wide selection of hard-to-find, seldom seen titles reflecting the range of the African American experience in the written tradition, from poetry and plays to fiction and fact, as well as newspapers,

photographs, prints and art books. On a national level, Cornerstone has worked with some very prominent scholars, such as Dr. Gates in his successful assertion of Eleanor Wilson's race, long presumed to be Caucasian, now firmly anchored by research as the first African American female novelist, with her book "Our Nig." Clearly the nation's finest Black female scholar, Paula Giddings has used Cornerstone's was in the vanguard of regaining prominence and respect for the works of anthropologist, Zora Neale Hurston among collectors. Her books now fetch a small fortune in first edition state. Locally the bookstore has worked with the John Jay Library's remarkable Harris Collection, filling the small holes in its poetry shelves. It has helped build a Langston Hughes collection for Providence's Langston Hughes Center for the Arts, the city's premier performance venue for people of color. And it has enjoyed long associations with Brown graduate students in pursuit of evasive materials on such subjects as George Schuyler, Blacks in aeronautic design and John Mercer Langston.

Cornerstone is home not just to the oddity or obscure, it is also the place where one can find the more accessible and inexpensive in blues and jazz, Black women's health or the latest in Afro-centric thought. If you are unfamiliar with Cornerstone Books, you should become acquainted with one of the most important resources in African American studies in New England. While it still remains an active mail order clientele, as far away as England, it welcomes the newcomer, or those who have overlooked it for the larger bookstores. It will be happy to assist you in finding that elusive book. And its proprietor will be happy to take time out to talk about his passion, Black American Books. Cornerstone is located at127 Thayer Street, open Monday through Saturday from 12 to 5 PM and can be reached at (401) 331-1340.

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